odd terrorist, in case the action to get him was going to lead to loss of innocent lives or cause unreasonable collateral damage.

A particular CO once told me that I was flogging his troops. He had mustered the guts to say so either because he knew that his confidential report would not be written by me or else, he was convinced that his troops were really overstretched. When this incident happened, 7 Sikh, the battalion in question, was deployed near the LoC. The next morning, I walked up to the Battalion HQ. It was a tough march uphill all the way and it took me about two hours or so. Besides, it was my third trip there in as many months. When I questioned the CO as to what prompted him to make such a remark, he tried to make excuses to justify that his battalion was fully stretched.

'How many times has the previous commander been here in the last one year?' I asked.

'Once, Sir,' was the colonel's reply.

'Look here, my friend, this is my third visit to your unit and therefore, if I am not sparing myself then you and your battalion jolly well get used to it. We are all here to do our assigned missions to the best of our abilities. Do you get me?'

'Yes Sir', he said. Things fell into place without any problems thereafter.

Earlier, another incident happened with the same unit. I got a call from their previous brigade commander, who asked me to let the CO visit his administrative base at Uri at least once a week. I did not agree as I felt that the operational situation demanded the presence of the CO. Infiltration was increasing and the challenge had to be met. I was okay with the CO going to Uri once in a while but not every week. But the brigadier carried on and on, and tried to convince me of how important it was for the colonel to visit his rear HQ. Finally, I proposed to the brigadier that since he was insistent, the CO could remain at Uri permanently. I would be quite content if all operational responsibilities were entrusted by him to the second-in-command. That was the last I ever heard on this issue.

Soon this battalion carried out a successful operation and effectively intercepted and eliminated a large group of heavily-